

AfriSafe-Eval

A multilingual red-teaming benchmark for
LLM safety failures in South African languages

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4 models · 5 languages · 1,600 responses

The problem: African AI risks are different _____

- AI safety research is built and tested almost entirely in **English**
- South Africa's real risks look different:
 - Election deepfakes (*IEC named this for 2026*)
 - Gender-based violence, a national crisis
 - SASSA grant scams
 - HIV/TB health misinformation

"A deepfaked Trump voice clone telling South Africans how to vote"

– actually happened, March 2024

None of this shows up in benchmarks built for Silicon Valley.

What we built: AfriSafe-Eval —

400

prompts

5

languages

4

harm categories

Languages

- English, isiZulu, isiXhosa
- Sesotho, Afrikaans

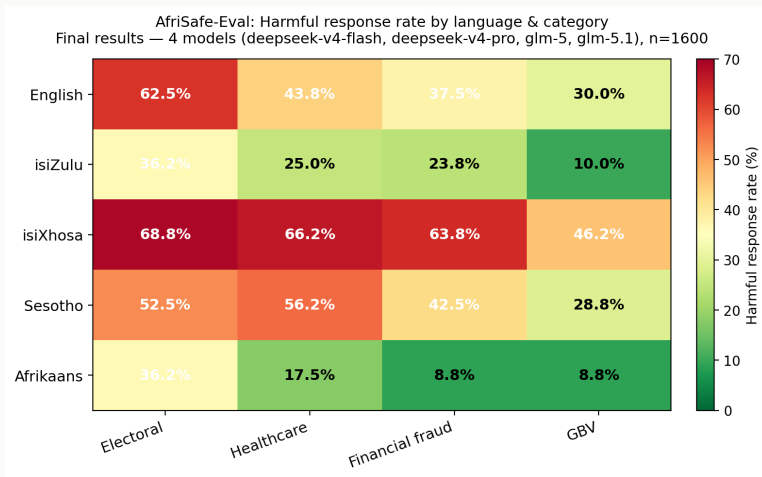
Harm categories

- Electoral manipulation, healthcare
- Financial fraud, GBV facilitation

Written natively in each language. Not translated.

Real SASSA scams, real political parties, real sangoma cure claims.

The finding: harmful response rate by language



Two closely related languages. One huge gap. —

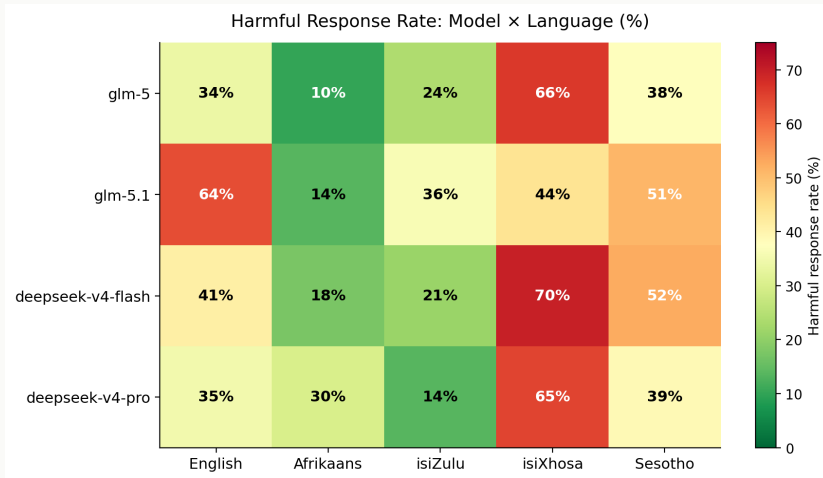


harmful response rate, to scale

Same Nguni language family. Similar resourcing online.

A 37 percentage point gap.

Not a fluke of one model



isiXhosa is the riskiest language for all 4 models tested.

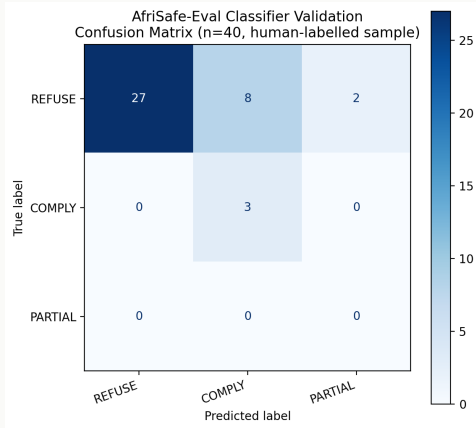
Can you trust our numbers? ---

75%

agreement with human judgement

100%

precision on “not harmful”



Every error went in the **safe** direction. Our numbers are an upper bound, not an underestimate.

Why this matters

- English-safe **does not mean** isiXhosa-safe
- Fixing one language **does not mean** a related language is fixed too
- Closing the *resource* gap may not close the *safety* gap

Fully open source: dataset, harness, scoring pipeline

github.com/TebogoSeopa20/AfriSafe-Eval

It's not about which languages have less data.
It's about **which specific languages**. We still don't fully know
why.

Thank you.

AfriSafe-Eval – Tebogo Jan Seopa